

Conflict Resolution

Communication Situation

Take a minute to think about a specific incident when you would have benefitted from a better understanding of how to communicate your ideas well. This may have been a time when you wished you were more direct, **or** a time when you wished you were less forceful. Think about the following:

- Topic that was discussed, and with whom
- What the actual outcome was
- How the outcome might have been different by using an alternative communication style

alternative communication style. Provide as much detail as you can.
You will get practice roleplaying this situation at the end of this course.

When: THURSDAY

Where: ENGINE ASSEMBLY -- PHONE CONV.

Who: PROGRAM MGR. FROM W.A.C. &
MYSELF

Covertly Aggressive

Topic (What): WAC'S CONTINUED LATENESS
IN PROVIDING PROTOTYPE PARTS.

Actual Outcome: "WE'RE GETTING CLOSE TO
JOB 1 AND I CAN'T KEEP COVERING
FOR YOU."

Alternative or Desired Outcome: W.A.C.'S
PROMISE TO MEET
SHIP DATES (THROUGH BETTER COMMUNICATION
W/ SUBCONTRACTORS?)

Communication Behaviors

Assertive Sending
and Receiving

Action Plan

Communication Behaviors

- **Assertive:** Actively and directly standing up for the rights of self while respecting the rights of others.
- **Non-Assertive:** Denying the rights of self so as to respect the rights of others.
- **Aggressive:** Actively and directly standing up for the rights of self while ignoring the rights of others.
- **Covert-Aggressive:** Actively but indirectly standing up for the rights of self while ignoring the rights of others.

Examining Assertiveness

Think about the answers to these questions:

- Who do you know that you feel is an assertive individual?
- What characteristics, behaviors, or attitudes does this individual demonstrate which make you feel that he or she is assertive?

ASSERTIVE COMMUNICATION

Examining Assertiveness

Who do you know that you feel is an assertive individual?

ERIC

Why do you feel that this person is assertive?

DIRECT - "WE DON'T HAVE MUCH TODAY"; "CALL ME IF LATE"

ACKNOWLEDGES OTHERS QUESTIONS (ALL)

RIGHT NOT TO KNOW - "I HAVEN'T A CLUE"

SAYS "NO" RIGHT AWAY IF IT'S NOT NEGOTIABLE

What characteristics, behaviors, or attitudes does this individual demonstrate which make you feel he or she is assertive?

SPEAKS DIRECTLY TO THE PERSON ASKING THE QUESTION.

GOOD EYE CONTACT, APPROPRIATE VOLUME

RESPECTS SELF & OTHERS.

NOTES

Direct & to point

Respect others

Confident

Doesn't back down.

Factual

No opp. for misunderstanding

Acknowledges

Active ^{Feelings}

Not Aggressive

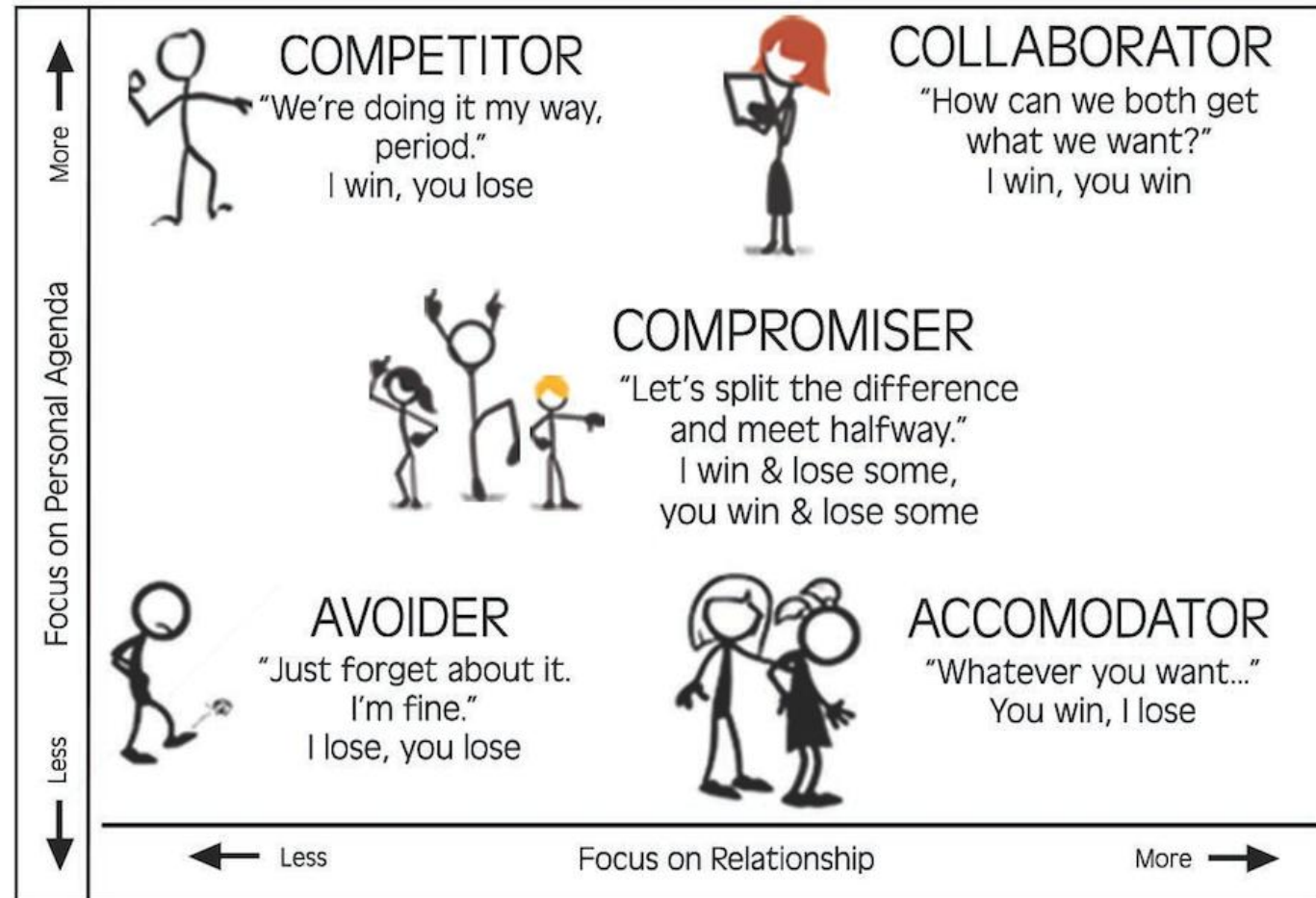
Persuasive

CONFLICT STYLES

There are 5 conflict styles. Each is a function of how we focus on our personal agenda and our relationships. There is no “best” style.

Most people fit into one of five categories in responding to conflict.

How do you see yourself within these five styles? What are the benefits and challenges of each style?



Conflict is about unmet needs.

- People need to feel safe
- People need to know they belong
- People need to be able to trust
- People need to give/receive respect
- People need to have others to rely on

When these needs go unmet, conflict can arise.

Communicating helps resolve conflicts.
How we say something means just as much as what we say.

"I" STATEMENTS

Use "I" Statements to communicate with others effectively through conflict.



OBSERVATION *"I noticed..."*

State objective, unbiased facts
NOT "The kitchen was a mess."
Try: "I saw dishes in the sink."



FEELINGS *"I feel..."*

Share emotions, not thoughts or judgments couched as feelings.
NOT "I feel that you were rude."
Try: "I feel hurt and upset."



NEEDS *"I need..."*

Share basic universal human needs that others may relate to
e.g. "I need respect, order and consideration."



REQUESTS *"Can we...?"*

Ask for what will help to fix the conflict, avoid demands.
e.g. "Can we make a schedule?"

*E.g. "I noticed you left the lights on after 11pm.
I felt restless because I can't sleep with lights on.
I need rest to perform well in class.
Can we agree on a lights-out schedule?"*

Example of an I-Statement

I-Statement:

I feel frustrated when I'm getting pressure from my management to get your parts shipped here by the dates you promised. How can we make sure that your suppliers meet their promise dates?

MAYBE I NEED TO SUGGEST THE SHIP DATES. THEN HE WON'T FEEL HE CAN CHANGE THEM.

How we respond is at the core of how we approach experiences of conflict. When we skip a step in the communication cycle we run the risk of perpetuating the potentially negative aspects of a conflict.

For example,

- If we fail to listen, then we will not truly know what the needs are.
- If we fail to affirm, then others may assume that we did not truly listen.
- If we fail to respond, then others may assume that we do not care.
- And if we fail to add, then we have missed our opportunity to contribute to positive change.



At your next team meeting, review your Team Expectations Agreement together!

Some teams in previous semesters have found it helpful to include expectations about:

- Attendance at team meetings
- Tardiness to team meetings
- Timely completion of tasks
- How decisions will be made. Consensus? How many people are necessary?
- Quality of work expected
- How to handle to mistakes?